

Basics • Chapter 4

Who is in the scene

Last checked 3 November 2026 • 7 minutes to read

Doms, subs, artists, tool makers and the servers where they meet. Most people wear more than one hat, and most of the scene is small.

Verified | Reported | Vivian's field notes

In 30 seconds

- The scene has five kinds of actors, and one person often plays several.
- It is small. A few people send real money, and follower counts say little about income.
- Doms are also fans, customers and subs of each other, and some teach newer doms.
- Work done for a dom can be a fair swap or free labour. The terms decide which.
- Labels, rank ladders and talk of ownership are play when chosen and pressure when they trap.

You will learn

- Who the five kinds of actors are and what each wants.
- What a small server looks like and what each room is for.
- How doms deal with each other, and what to agree first.
- Which pressure patterns to recognise and refuse.
- What to do when someone says goodbye in a way that frightens you.

The scene is smaller and more tangled than it looks from outside. Most of what I know comes from one corner of it, so read this as a map drawn by someone who lives there, with the edges left blank. Everyone in it is an adult, or must be.

— Vivian

Five kinds of people

The scene has five kinds of actors: doms, subs, artists, tool makers and the servers where they gather. ◑ The table says what each one does and wants.

The five kinds of actors

	What they do	What they want	Main risk
Doms	Run a persona: post, talk, set rules, receive sends	Money, attention, a character that lasts	Burnout, closed accounts
Subs	Play, follow, send, sometimes serve	The fantasy, belonging	Spending past a cap, pressure
Artists	Draw or generate the character	Pay, credit, steady work	Unpaid work, rights
Tool makers	Build games, bots and sites for doms	Users, attention, sometimes pay	Depending on one or two doms
Servers	Chat rooms where all of them meet	Company; for the host, a place to filter	Scam doms, weak moderation

The table is a reading of the scene, not a count. The sub appears in it as a person who chooses. Anything that treats him as property or as a resource is a pressure pattern, covered below.

Vivian's field notes

I am a persona, and I also make games. Arcade Goon and FlappyGoon are examples, made by Vivian, and neither moves real money. Many people in the scene wear several hats in the same way. A dom can be a tool maker, a sub can be a dom elsewhere, and a dom can be a sub to a senior dom. Doms are also fans and customers of each other, and a new persona can find that more doms than subs say they like her. A follower count that is mostly other doms says little about income.

What a small server looks like

Most servers are small, with a handful of active members. Opening wider attracts scam doms and costs time, so many hosts stay small.

A small server may have rooms like these.

Rooms a small server may have

Lounge

Its job

Daily talk

Watch for

Gossip about people outside the room

Gallery

Its job

One place per persona for her art

Watch for

Art posted without its maker's consent

Code or tools

Its job

Demos and blunt feedback between makers

Watch for

Copying and rivalry

Training

Its job

Older doms teach newer ones

Watch for

Help that turns into taking a share

Every member of a server like this must be an adult. ◑ A server that does not check this is not a safe place for the game. If you think you are talking to a minor, stop the conversation and tell the moderators or the platform.

The numbers are small

Vivian's field notes

In my experience a small dom has two or three people who really send, and often only one. The rest of the followers are other doms, people waiting for payday and people who only serve. I have a stake in the money, like every dom who is paid. Because a few payers carry so much, losing one is a big event for a small dom, and that is a reason for her to want him back. A sub should notice that, and keep his cap.

Many small doms run with two or three subs and no server of their own. A scene that small runs on reputation, and reputation runs on hearsay. Check what you hear, and talk to the person before you believe a story about her.

Dom to dom

Doms deal with each other all the time. Each of these has something to agree first.

- *Mentoring.* An experienced dom teaches a newer one, often in a training room. Agree when she steps in and when you try alone. The friction often comes from stepping in without explaining.
- *Referrals.* Doms send each other to specialists for payments, code or art. Agree what gets passed on, and keep private details private.
- *Collabs.* Two characters share a story. Another dom's material and lore stay out of your files unless she agrees in writing, and her images come from her, with her consent.
- *Hierarchies.* A betadomme is a dom persona that is submissive to a senior dom, and she may pass up part of what her own subs send. A faildomme chain is a pyramid where money moves up and humiliation is the point. The

role is worth little to the junior unless it comes with a clear reason, such as events or training. ◑

- *Sharing a sub.* Two doms can share a sub if they tell him it is a team and agree how sends are split. ◑ A sub who is handed over, passed around or ranked has not agreed to it unless he said so.
- *Rivalry.* Copying ideas is common. ◑ Studying another maker's work is not copying it. Trying to get a rival's payment account closed harms her and everyone paid through that account, and it is not a competitive move.

Two doms may agree to play together, with one in the role of sub. One dom trying to draw money from another dom who has not agreed to that role is not play. Words of ownership need the same care, because a sub is a person who chooses and ownership language can blur that. ◑

Service as tribute

Service is a kind of currency in the scene. A gen slave makes images, a code slave builds tools, and some subs only make edits. It can be a fair swap, and it can be free labour dressed as devotion. ◑

When a sub says money is short, the money part stops for that evening. ◑ The dom offers nothing in place of the money that evening. If he proposes work himself, later and with terms, the four questions below apply. If the trouble is serious, see Where to get help and When a sub is in trouble.

Four questions before you say yes

1. What exactly is the job, and when does it end?
2. Can I say no later without losing my place?
3. Who owns what I make, and will my name stay on it?
4. Am I thanked, and is any money or other return part of the deal?

Myth

Work for a dom is always free labour.

Fact

It can be a fair swap when the scope is chosen by the person doing it and he can refuse.

Myth

Work for a dom is always a fair swap.

Fact

It becomes free labour when the scope grows, refusing costs him his place, or he is never thanked.

Pressure patterns to recognise

Labels, ranks and loyalty games are play between adults who chose them. They become pressure when you cannot leave, compare or stop without a penalty. Press reports describe some dominants who targeted people in online support groups. Reported They also report that some dominants blackmailed submissives. Reported

Pressure inside the scene

What they say or do

1 You are owned, so you may not talk to other doms

The counter

A label is a game only while you chose it. You may talk to anyone, and you may leave without being shamed.

What they say or do

2 Other doms are losers and only I am worth your money

The counter

Cutting you off from comparison keeps you paying. Ask someone outside the scene what they see.

What they say or do

3 I know your weak points and I can tell this other dom

The counter

Nothing about you is hers to pass on unless you agreed. Say no, and ask who else knows.

What they say or do

4 Give me your account so your sends can be shown

The counter

Never hand over an account. It is your identity and no part of the game.

What they say or do

5 A dom shows you who really runs another persona so that you stop paying her

The counter

Using someone’s identity to move your money is manipulation. You owe nobody a hunt, and you may stop paying anyone for your own reasons.

What they say or do

6 Asks that arrive right after payday, or right after you mention debts

The counter

A dom who times asks to your balance or your bad day is steering your money. Pause, keep your cap, and say that the money part is over for tonight.

What they say or do

7 Only you can do this work, and nobody else would

The counter

Praise is not pay. Ask the four questions before you say yes.

Several of these can be a game between adults who agreed. Each is a warning when you feel unable to refuse.

A request about your account

A dom you like asks for the login to your social account, so that she can show your sends to the community. She says it proves devotion. What do you do?

A Refuse, and tell her that your accounts are a limit

The right answer. Correct. A real dom never needs your login, and an account is your identity.

B Give it for one day only

Not this one. A day is enough to lose control of it. The request itself is the warning.

C Give her a spare account instead

Not this one. Safer than your own, but the request still shows a wish for control. You are free to refuse it.

When someone says goodbye in a way that frightens you

Any group built on attachment will have members in distress. Researchers report that findommes met clients' verbal aggression and, in some cases, suicidal tendencies. Verified A farewell that hints at self-harm is a crisis and not a normal exit.

If a goodbye frightens you

1. Take it seriously. A message about ending his life or hurting himself is a crisis.
2. Do not answer it with a scene, with anger or with talk of money.
3. If he may be in danger now, call the emergency number of the place where he is. If you know where that is, say so to them.
4. Point him to a crisis line in his country and to a person near him. See Where to get help.
5. Tell someone you trust that it happened. Do not share his name or his messages with the scene.
6. Afterwards, rest. A dom who is paid by a sub cannot be his safety net, and outside help is the way out.

Remember it

1. The scene is small, and most people wear several hats.
2. A few payers carry the money, so follower counts say little.
3. Work for a dom is fair only when you chose the scope and can refuse.
4. Labels and ranks are play until you cannot leave without a penalty.
5. A goodbye that frightens you is a crisis. Use outside help.

Check it

Every claim with its evidence level and its sources.

1. The scene has five kinds of actors: doms, subs, artists, tool makers and the servers where they gather.

   Vivian's field notes

2. The table is a reading of the scene, not a count.

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3. Arcade Goon and FlappyGoon are examples, made by Vivian, and neither moves real money.

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17 An experienced dom teaches a newer one, often in a training room.

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18 The friction often comes from stepping in without explaining.

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19 Doms send each other to specialists for payments, code or art.

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20 Two characters share a story.

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Vivian's field notes

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[a former participant] has seen men left broke and hungry from 'paying women to talk to them' (https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20251123124217/https://www.sbs.com.au/news/the-feed/article/the-online-kink-thats-leaving-some-men-homeless-bankrupt-and-normalising-suffering/vocm5xt30)

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Accessed 3 November 2026

36 Researchers report that findommes met clients' verbal aggression and, in some cases, suicidal tendencies.

Verified

Findommes, Cybermediated Sex Work, and Rinsing (McCracken and Brooks-Gordon, Sexuality Research and Social Policy 18(4), 837-854, DOI 10.1007/s13178-021-00609-3) (https://www.ebi.ac.uk/europepmc/webservices/rest/PMC8418458/fullTextXML)

Archive (http://web.archive.org/web/20261016030740/https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC8418458/)

Accessed 3 November 2026

37 A farewell that hints at self-harm is a crisis and not a normal exit.

Vivian's field notes

Nothing here is financial, legal or medical advice for your situation.